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BETTER CITIES FOR A BETTER LIFE

► Many Indians move abroad in search of a better life. Who doesn't want cleaner, more liveable cities with fewer worries about personal safety? State and municipal governments in India have their work cut out to make towns and cities more liveable with affordable housing, 24x7 water and electricity, sanitation and recycling facilities. There is an urgent need for urban green codes, including rooftop gardens, solar panels and water reuse. Municipal and infrastructure bonds could help finance these initiatives



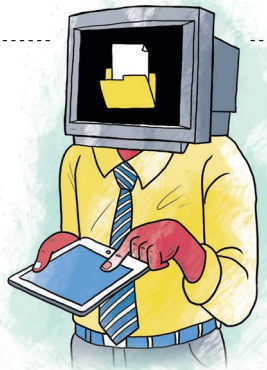
CLEAN UP ELECTION FUNDING

► As many as 646 million voters participated in the 2024 General Elections to elect 543 candidates to the Lok Sabha. Each candidate is estimated to have spent an average ₹57.2 lakh for campaigning. Where these funds come from is a question voters often ask. Electoral reforms are the need of the hour for transparency in funding to political parties, especially by India Inc. This will bring clarity in the stance taken by elected representatives on policy measures as well as lower pressure on companies to pay for elections.

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SCALE UP DIGITAL PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE

► Leveraging India's existing digital public infrastructure and bringing together all government services on a single portal could improve ease of living. Integration of Artificial Intelligence in government policies could also enhance delivery of benefits and improve outcomes. For employers, the implementation of a State Employer Compliance Grid is crucial for digitising compliances.

FEDERATE THE FISC

► The Goods and Services Tax (GST) has shown that the Centre and states can work together to raise revenues. Enabling states and local governments to have an adequate say in their finances is important for the next generation of reforms. The government needs to go back to the drawing board to work out a more equitable distribution of taxes. States must be made more responsible for fiscal discipline as well as spending plans.

